

SWINE FLU: Do We Need To Worry Any More?

The general impression is that the H1N1 virus is not as virulent as once feared. So did we all panic needlessly over the swine flu scare? Here's why you still need to be on guard:



Age Matters

The virus is infecting young people—from youngsters in the late teens to those in their mid-20s—who should ideally have healthy immune systems. There are few cases of swine flu in people over 50.

No Vaccine Yet

Right now, it's sensitive to anti-virals like Tamiflu. But it may become drug-resistant and morph into a deadlier form.

Even if makers start brewing vaccine doses, it will take months to test their immunity and safety.

Even if a vaccine is ordered, would the developing world get a fair share?

Seasonal flu time is round the corner.

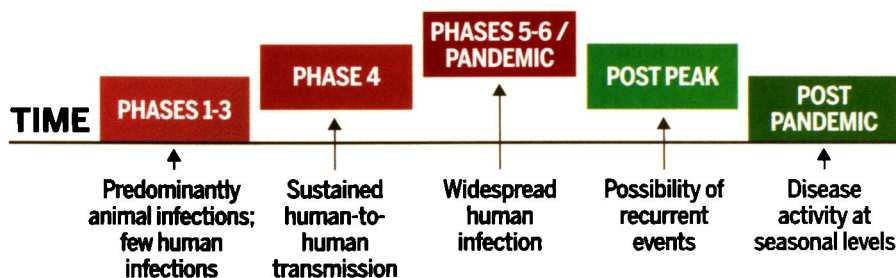
Are we breathing a sigh of relief too soon?



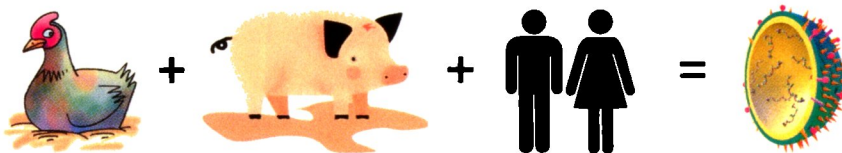
* Source: World Health Organization, Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, US and National Institute of Allergy and Infectious Diseases (NIAID).

Panic Alert Still On

The World Health Organization (WHO) has pressed the alert button at Phase 5-6—the first such for flu since 1968. A pandemic is declared when outbreaks occur in two countries in one region of the globe and at least one in another region.



We've Never Seen Anything Like This Before



WHO says the virus is unpredictable and constantly changing. This explains its present form as a combination of genes from birds, pigs and human beings. It has the potential of a pandemic. A deadly Type A, it can replicate, infect and spread easily among human beings.

IT'S CONSTANTLY EVOLVING

The new virus is spreading. The WHO reports over 3,440 lab-confirmed cases in 29 countries and 48 deaths. If it spreads farther, the chances of it mixing with other flu viruses in circulation will increase, thereby turning it into something more lethal.



■ Compiled by **Damayanti Datta**